important insights would be rewarded with prizes and prestige. Universities would compete to hire the leading figures in the area, dangling superstar salaries to lure them away from rival institutions.

Sadly, no. Not only is the quest to make sense of quantum mechanics not considered a high-status specialty within modern physics; in many quarters it's considered barely respectable at all, if not actively disparaged. Most physics departments have nobody working on the problem, and those who choose to do so are looked upon with suspicion. (Recently while writing a grant proposal, I was advised to concentrate on describing my work in gravitation and cosmology, which is considered legitimate, and remain silent about my work on the foundations of quantum mechanics, as that would make me appear less serious.) There have been important steps forward over the last ninety years, but they have typically been made by headstrong individuals who thought the problems were important despite what all of their colleagues told them, or by young students who didn't know any better and later left the field entirely.

In one of Aesop's fables, a fox sees a juicy bunch of grapes and leaps to reach it, but can't quite jump high enough. In frustration he declares that the grapes were probably sour, and he never really wanted them anyway. The fox represents "physicists," and the grapes are "understanding quantum mechanics." Many researchers have decided that understanding how nature really works was never really important; all that matters is the ability to make particular predictions.

Scientists are trained to value tangible results, whether they are exciting experimental findings or quantitative theoretical models. The idea of working to understand a theory we already have, even if that effort might not lead to any specific new technologies or predictions, can be a tough sell. The underlying tension was illustrated in the TV show *The Wire*, where a group of hardworking detectives labored for months to meticulously gather evidence that would build a case against a powerful drug ring. Their bosses, meanwhile, had no patience for such incremental frivolity. They just wanted to see drugs on the table for their next press conference, and encouraged the police to bang heads and make splashy arrests. Funding agencies and hiring committees are like those bosses. In a world where all the incentives push us toward concrete, quantifiable outcomes, less pressing big-picture concerns can be pushed aside as we race toward the next immediate goal.